The thinking behind StepUp

Background notes based on my original Areas 1 and 2 draft. These explain the idea, the problem I am trying to address and how I see the solution working.

Who I am designing StepUp for

The customer segment selected for this exercise is Irish public sector employees preparing for internal promotions through competency based recruitment. These individuals have practical experience but they can struggle to identify and communicate evidence of their achievements against the competencies relevant to the role. They also struggle to match them to the role requirements, identify gaps in their experience, and prepare structured STAR (situation, task, action, result) answers. The proposed solution is an end-to-end promotion preparation platform that helps employees organise their achievements, identify gaps in their evidence, prepare STAR method responses and practise competency based interview questions. Preparing presentations is also common in these scenarios and thus, providing support in this area is required. The primary users include individual employees who fall into this remit. Organisations could potentially invest in this tool through learning and development strategies to better enhance their employees skillset within the company.

The problem I want to solve

The following is an illustrative first-person statement from my draft, rather than a verified customer testimonial:

‘I have multiple years of experience in various roles, however I struggle to map my examples to the relevant competencies and turn them into STAR answers when applying for internal promotions. I am the type of person that can execute a task to a very high standard and exceed expectations, though I don’t always translate that well into words. I find it challenging to identify my strongest examples and explain how they align to the competencies for the next grade. My personal goal is to continue to progress within my not-for-profit organisation and thus, I need something that can help me organise my achievements, identify where my evidence lacks detail, and practise translating my experience into strong interview answers. Ideally, I would like to receive feedback so that I can build and improve on my answers ahead of the interview’.

What the platform needs to do

- Allow users to enter the competency and capabilities required for the specific role
- Let user record, edit, and save their achievements
- Map their achievements to the competencies and highlight gaps in evidence
- Help users structure their answers based on the situation, task, action and result.
- Provide interview questions, feedback, and allow for a second attempt
- Access through a mobile device is required and the information must save after refreshing the page.

How people prepare today

In today’s world, candidates typically prepare by analysing the job description for a given role, review the competency framework and develop STAR answers based on both. Practising with friends and family is common to better prepare for the interview itself. Whilst these methods can be beneficial, organising professional achievements, matching them to competencies, and preparing answers can be challenging when reviewing multiple sources.

I also looked at two existing services when preparing my draft (checked on 26 October 2026):

- Publicjobs.ie provides support on competency based and capability based interviews including STAR responses and preparation – see below. The source was checked and validates on 26th October 2026. https://www.publicjobs.ie/documents/PAS_CS_Competency_Models_2017.pdf
- Starmethod.ie is a similar product that provides STAR based interview tool, feedback and presentation practise. Whilst this is a competitor, my proposed tool differentiates as it includes an evidence planning process through organising achievements, mapping competiencies, highlighting gaps, as well as interview practise. The below source was accessed on 26th October 2026. https://starmethod.ie/practice/

My proposed solution

The proposed solution is a website based promotion preparation platform designed for Irish public-sector employees seeking internal promotion. It combines an evidence planner with competency-based interview practice, helping users organise their professional achievements and prepare stronger interview responses.

The platform aims to make promotion preparation more structured by connecting the user's experience to the requirements of their target role.

I see the process working in three steps:

1. Enter the target role: The user selects or enters their target role and adds the relevant competencies or capabilities from the job description.
2. Organise professional evidence: The user records examples of their work achievements and maps them to the relevant competencies. The platform highlights competencies for which the user has not yet recorded supporting evidence. Users can then organise selected achievements using the STAR method.
3. Practise and improve: The user answers competency-based interview questions linked to their target role. They receive feedback on their answers, can make improvements and practise again. Presentation preparation may also be included for roles requiring a presentation.

How this links to the demo

The demo includes target role and competency entry, an evidence bank, evidence-gap mapping, a STAR builder and interview practice with rule-based feedback and retry. It is designed to work on a phone and save records in the current browser. The demo does not automatically sync between devices; workspace transfer is manual.

Presentation preparation is an idea for a future version, rather than a feature I have completed. The feedback in the current demo is rule-based, not AI-powered.

How StepUp could be sustained

The proposed business model is based on a freemium approach. Users could access basic evidence-planning and STAR preparation features for free, with a potential paid subscription offering additional interview practice, more detailed feedback and presentation preparation.

An alternative revenue stream could involve organisations purchasing access for employees through their Learning and Development departments.

As an initial assumption for testing, a premium subscription could cost €5 per month per individual. This is a proposed price, not a validated market rate. The viability of this model would depend on user demand,

development and operating costs, and willingness to pay.

The main ongoing costs could include hosting, maintenance and any AI services used to provide feedback. The long-term sustainability of the platform would depend on whether subscription income or organisational funding could cover those costs.

Designing for how people will actually use it

Users may prepare for promotion outside working hours or during short breaks, so the platform should be simple to navigate on a mobile phone. Forms should use clear labels, short sections and readable text. Achievement records should be easy to edit, and users should be able to move between competencies without losing their work. Progress and missing evidence should be clearly visible, without requiring users to read long instructions. These requirements will be checked by testing the demo on a phone as well as a laptop.

These are project notes, not evidence of commercial demand or independently verified user outcomes.